

lord's occult lair may have strange breezes and the chatter of unearthly voices in the mortal world as well.

One of the oddest problems of a freehold is the issue of being bigger on the inside, which happens when the freehold on the fae side is much larger than its mortal side's interiors. It often takes time for a new fledgling to understand the "physics" of a freehold, and the connection between its Autumn world space and its corresponding pocket in the Dreaming.

The Glamour provided by freeholds allows Kithain to survive in the Autumn world. For that reason, freeholds are the cornerstone of Kithain society, as those that control these important places of power become themselves important. Noble houses build their structures around maintaining their freeholds and guard them zealously, while commoners do the same for their gathering places.

More than acting as simply gathering places, freeholds can become the only homes for many Kithain who must abandon their mortal lives when they go through their Chrysalis. Older changelings seeking to stave off old age and Banality's effects spend more and more time inside the freehold, partaking of its font of Glamour. Because freeholds are so important, Kithain become ferociously protective of them. Anyone challenging the ownership of a freehold or found endangering it will find themselves on the receiving end of a vicious dispute. Protection of freeholds in danger of destruction is one of changeling society's highest-held accords.

The heart of a freehold, much like the sacred stone at the heart of a glade, is the *bale re*, or the *Ignis Vesta*, the freehold's *balefire*. As long as the balefire continues burning, the freehold remains in existence and produces Glamour for its inhabitants. But should the balefire ever go out, the freehold might crumble under the force of Banality. During the Shattering, many freeholds were left abandoned by the fleeing nobles with their balefires yet lit. These embers, left untended, may have gone out, but many remain smoldering, waiting to be rediscovered. In North America, the source of all balefires is the Great Balefire that burns in the stronghold of High King David at Tara-Nar.

It is possible to create more freeholds. The creator of the freehold must bring balefire from another freehold and offer up their own Glamour as a permanent sacrifice to create the space. Most changelings instead seek to find abandoned freeholds in the hope that they can create new homes for themselves.

When a changeling does find a freehold, she must swear an oath and invest Glamour into the site to reawaken and claim it. Once she does so, no one else may claim it until the guardian dies or gives it away. The guardian of the freehold receives Glamour from that freehold and may also grant permission to others to receive the freehold's Glamour. Should any changeling attempt to steal from the freehold's Glamour supply, a process called *Reaving*, the freehold may be damaged or even destroyed. All changelings of a freehold are dedicated to its upkeep and defense.

Freeholds fall into several different categories, which are discussed in Chapter Seven (p. 312).

TRODS

A web of magical paths crosses both the mundane world and all points in the Dreaming. These pathways have existed for centuries, and though they have degraded and some branches have become lost over time, the system of *trods* that branch throughout known (and unknown) space are an important transportation system for changelings everywhere. During the Shattering, many of the trods that led to locations in the Dreaming, as well as the primary ways that led to Arcadia, slammed shut. The Interregnum saw more and more of these gates fade away, until few trods functioned. With the return of the sidhe during the Resurgence, and with the constant mini-explosions of Glamour driving more doorways open, changelings have taken to the trods to see where they might lead. So far, none of them have led back to Arcadia. Many, though, have led seekers into deeper parts of the Dreaming, and into adventures and dangers they could never have imagined.

Trods allow changelings to travel from place to place without the fear of Banality. They may use their arts freely without expending Glamour and can travel from one freehold to another without stepping into the mortal world. Yet, after 600 years of erosion and disrepair, many trods no longer go where they used to, and many dead end in parts of the Dreaming. Trods also don't always take a direct route to their destination and can lead changeling travelers on long journeys before they emerge at their intended location. Some may arrive quickly and simply, but others may emerge with tales of long adventures and harrowing escapes in places unknown. Time is not reliable while traveling by trod, and some trips may stretch out time within the trod, or else make an extended trip through the Dreaming last only the blink of an eye in the mortal world.

Along the way, changelings may discover new and as-yet-undiscovered parts of the Dreaming, the realm from which they were born. It certainly isn't a tame place, but no changeling can escape stepping out of the mortal realm and into its borders for long. Yet as long as travelers follow the *Silver Path*, the silvery lifeline that connects one end of the trod to the other, Kithain can always find their way home. Of course, predators within the Dreaming know this, and often devise traps and obstacles along the paths that a changeling must face if they wish to escape unscathed. And though they may leave, no one who enters the Dreaming truly comes back unchanged. The adventure might be worth it, though.

The Dreaming

The Dreaming is a realm created by the creativity, fantasies, and revelries of humanity, a realm of infinite possibilities outside and separate from the mortal realm. A boundless space outside of the rules of physics, time, and known reality, the Dreaming is a place where anything can happen and probably has already. It is a place woven into the fabric of the mortal world, hidden behind and without, though its magic and influence can affect the physical world and those that live in it.